

ACING ACT TEST BODES WELL FOR GREATER CHALLENGES AHEAD

With the Hockey India League approaching, the Pro League will be the **next chance** for this squad to play together for India.

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Even before the Asian Champions Trophy (ACT) was officially announced, it was evident that the Indian women's hockey team would be markedly different from what it had been for some time. A new coach, new challenges, and significant baggage to shed meant the tournament — regardless of its position in the hierarchy of major international competitions — would be important as both a measure of recent developments and a precursor to future prospects.



India found itself in the unique position of being the defending champion while dealing with a long string of losses, a restructured team composition, and a new management espousing a completely different philosophy and style of play compared to former coach Janneke Schopman. That the host managed to retain the title despite these challenges augurs well for the team. **However, it didn't come easy, and the road ahead will only get tougher for coach Harendra Singh and his squad.**

By all accounts, the event in Rajgir served as